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Capitalist mutations in emerging, intermediate and peripheral neoliberalism

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The emerging economies are as fascinating as they are difficult to interpret. They include countries which are neither integrated into the bloc of developed nations, nor on the marginalised periphery. They have expanded, gaining a certain space in the world market and increasing their geopolitical influence. But it is not easy to distinguish among the members of this sector. As often happens with labels made popular in the media, the term has been popularised before it has been clearly defined. It is applied indiscriminately to various economies, without differentiating China from the pack of emerging economies. This sort of generalisation stands in the way of us recognising the most important qualitative transformation of the current period: the conversion of the Asian giant into a world power.

China's road to capitalism

China is already becoming part of the core countries and has far outpaced any other emerging economy. It has become the world's workshop and enjoys an insertion into the global economy which is very different from those countries providing primary materials or subcontracting services. China's new position in the world hierarchy is crowned by the strengthening of its industrial sector. This mutation is the result of a dizzying growth which increased per capita GDP 22 times between 1980 and 2011 (from US$220 to US$4930), while purchasing power has grown by 33 times. The country's commercial volume has doubled every four years over that same period. In 2001, Chinese commercial transactions